

EIGHTY BUCKS

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.1

INT. JONAH'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A one-bedroom that was recently a one-person apartment. You can tell because everything in it is trying to pretend it still is.

The door opens carefully. JONAH (26), work bag, keys already silenced in his fist, enters his own home like a burglar.

Because on the couch, asleep at 9:40 PM under a jacket instead of a blanket: MARCUS (26). Work boots by the door, placed straight. A duffel bag beside the couch, packed, zipped.

It has been beside the couch, packed, zipped, for three months.

Jonah stands in his kitchen and eats cereal in the dark, quietly, so as not to wake the man sleeping in the middle of his life.

MAIN TITLE: EIGHTY BUCKS

INT. JONAH'S APARTMENT - BATHROOM - MORNING

Jonah brushes his teeth. His toothbrush stands in the cup by the tap. Alone in the cup.

On the shelf below, tucked half-inside a toiletry bag that's tucked half-inside a jacket sleeve: a second toothbrush.

Three months, and Marcus has never once put his toothbrush in the cup. The cup is for people who live here.

INT. JONAH'S APARTMENT - KITCHEN - MORNING

Marcus, up, dressed, boots on, dish towel over his shoulder. The kitchen is immaculate. Aggressively immaculate. The counters gleam with apology.

MARCUS

I did the thing with the drain.
The gurgle. It doesn't gurgle now.

JONAH

You didn't have to fix my drain.

MARCUS

It gurgled.

On the counter: groceries. Good ones. The expensive orange juice, the one Jonah buys when he's sad.

JONAH
Marcus. You can't keep buying groceries.

MARCUS
Everybody eats, man.

JONAH
You can't keep buying the sad juice. That's nine dollars.

MARCUS
(a grin with scaffolding under it)
Nothing sad about it. It's got the pulp.

He laughs half a beat too hard at his own line, and takes his boots out the door to a job that used to be full-time.

INT. JONAH'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Jonah and Marcus on the couch, a game on the TV with the sound low. Two beers, one bag of chips positioned exactly between them with diplomatic precision.

This part works. This part has worked since ninth grade.

MARCUS
He should've passed there.

JONAH
He's never passed in his life.

MARCUS
Man's allergic to teammates.

Companionable silence. Then, into the blue light, without looking over:

JONAH
You know you can use the dresser.
There's two empty drawers.

A pause the length of a decision.

MARCUS
I'm good. Bag works.

The game plays on. Neither of them says anything else. The duffel sits in the corner of both their eyelines, packed, zipped, ready to prove at any moment that none of this is happening.

INT. JONAH'S APARTMENT - 3 AM

Jonah, up for water, stops in the hallway.

Marcus is awake. Sitting up on the couch in the dark, TV off, phone face-up on his knee, not looking at it. Just sitting. A man doing math with no numbers left.

Jonah stands in the dark of the hallway, holding his glass.

He could go in. Everything in the apartment is his, including the silence, and he could go in.

He goes back to bed. The coward's mercy, or the merciful cowardice. Even he can't tell, lying there, listening to nothing.

INT. JONAH'S APARTMENT - EVENING

Jonah comes home. Stops one step inside.

The couch is bare. Cushions squared. The jacket-blanket folded over the armrest with terrible neatness, like a flag returned.

The duffel is by the door. Boots next to it. And Marcus is in the kitchen wiping a counter that is already clean, wearing the face of a man who has rehearsed something.

MARCUS

Hey — so. Kev's got a couch. His roommate moved in with the girlfriend, so there's space, it's closer to the site anyway, so.

JONAH

Kev lives with his mother.

Beat.

MARCUS

His mother has a couch.

JONAH

Marcus.

MARCUS
(still wiping the clean
counter)

You've been a brother about it,
man, but three months is — I can
hear you being quiet, you know
that? Every night. Guy creeping
around his own apartment so I
don't have to feel like —

He stops wiping.

MARCUS (CONT'D)
I was gonna be out by June. Then
July. It's August, Jonah.

JONAH
I know what month it is.

MARCUS
Then you know.

He goes for the duffel. Jonah steps — not in the way,
exactly. Adjacent to the way.

JONAH
Where'd it go? Just tell me that.
You worked six days a week. Where
did it go?

Marcus stands there holding the bag. And then, because it's
Jonah, because it's been ninth grade for seventeen years, he
puts it down and tells the floor:

MARCUS
Hours got cut in April. Half
shifts. Rent was — her name was on
the lease, and when that ended I
had eleven days to find something.
First and last everywhere is —
(the number, memorized,
bitter)
— eleven hundred and forty
dollars, minimum, for a basement
with a hot plate. I've got six
hundred and change and it doesn't
grow. It shrinks. It shrinks
because everybody eats, man.

Silence. The sad juice sits on the counter between them with
its nine-dollar pulp.

MARCUS (CONT'D)
My dad thinks I have an apartment.
He tells people I have an
apartment.

JONAH
You have an apartment.

MARCUS
I have a couch and a bag, and the
bag stays packed so it's – a
visit. It's a long visit.

There it is. Three months, said out loud in one breath.
Marcus looks lighter and about nine years older.

Jonah goes to the kitchen drawer. The junk one. Digs out a
notepad with a plumber's logo and a pen that half works.
Writes. Tears the page. Slides it across the counter like a
verdict.

On the page, in bad handwriting:

\$80/MONTH. UTILITIES INCLUDED. FIRST OF THE MONTH. NO END
DATE.

Marcus reads it twice.

MARCUS (CONT'D)
This isn't rent. This is charity
with math on it.

JONAH
It's rent. Eighty bucks, every
month, and I will hound you for it
like a landlord, I promise. Late
fees. Passive-aggressive texts.
The whole thing.

MARCUS
Eighty bucks is nothing.

JONAH
Eighty bucks is rent, which makes
you a tenant, which makes this
your address.
(beat)
Tenants tell their dads their
address, Marcus. Tenants put their
toothbrush in the cup.

Marcus looks at him. Looks at the paper. His jaw does
something complicated and comes out the other side level.

MARCUS
You know about the toothbrush.

JONAH
Everyone knows about the
toothbrush. It's the saddest
toothbrush in Ontario.

Marcus laughs – one real beat of it, no scaffolding – and picks up the pen that half works, and signs the plumber's notepad like it's a lease, because as of this moment it is.

MARCUS
I'm negotiating the late fees.

JONAH
Take it up with your landlord.

INT. JONAH'S APARTMENT - BATHROOM - MORNING

The cup by the tap.

Two toothbrushes.

Nobody in the shot. Just the cup, and the morning light doing what it can with a rental bathroom, which today is plenty.

INT. JONAH'S APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS

Marcus, crouched at the closet, unpacking the duffel. Actually unpacking it – three months of readiness coming out in folded stacks into two empty drawers.

He flattens the empty bag and puts it up on the closet shelf.

JONAH (O.S.)
(from the kitchen)
Closet space isn't in the deal.

MARCUS
(not turning around)
Eighty-five.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END